has revealed how good governance can be distorted as excessive state control or how anarchy and worse are justified as exercise of democratic rights. A polity that is oblivious to such practices is a society in danger.

The globalized era encouraged the promotion of an integrated broad truth, magnified by well-crafted echo chambers. The unfolding of multipolarity has, however, brought back the natural diversity of our planet. In the ensuing competition, there is always the possibility of both misunderstanding and misrepresentation. Since so much in security derives from perception, we cannot be impervious to the shaping of our image. If we expect an easy passage up the global hierarchy of power, we will be deluding ourselves. How to define norms, where to shine the spotlight, which parts of reality are picked, these are all par for the course. So, too, are the adjectives used in reporting, the free pass from fact-checking and the selectivity of judgement. But knowing full well the bias and interests, it is still a contest that we have to enter with zest and vigour. Creating and propagating our own narratives is, therefore, of great importance. Sections of the world have their views, but we should not be intimidated from having a view on those views. Swimming upstream is the karma of all rising powers.

THE ROAD AHEAD

Building adequate state capacities to deal with a more complex security matrix is a common challenge for larger nations. The very tools that allow us to render more effective services can also help to secure our people better. As with more orthodox external threats, conducting security policy in an informationized environment is the task for which we need to prepare fully. It will have its own challenges and debates, but the direction that we need to move in is difficult to dispute.

The world may have changed in many ways, but an incessant challenge that India grapples with is that of terrorism. That the dangers it poses to the international community are realized is a matter of satisfaction. But to the extent that compromises are made for political gains or regional strategy, it is a reminder of the task that remains. As a primary victim, we cannot expect that others will fight for our cause if we do not do so ourselves. Mobilizing world opinion must be accompanied by a robust defence of our own interests. In the realm of ideas, it is also important that the trap of